Disputes over Cultural Power in Digital Repatriation: Insufficient Interpretations of Cultural Objects in Cross-cultural Contexts Comparative analysis of metadata of ancient Chinese paintings in museums

wang, yujue
yujue.wang@whu.edu.cn
Wuhan University, the People's Republic of China

fan, jingya
1825370018@qq.com
Wuhan University, the People's Republic of China

wen, hanying
483461395@qq.com
Wuhan University, the People's Republic of China

Research Background

Due to political turmoil, aggressive wars, illegal trade and other reasons, **countless cultural relics are currently scattered outside their source communities and detached from original cultural backgrounds globally** , leading to cultural hegemony worldwide. For example, there are more than **10 million** Chinese cultural relics scattered around the world. Modern digitization technologies help transforming cultural relics into digital format, thus intriguing a new way called **“digital repatriation"** for dispersed cultural relics(Poske 2025). However, there are great power imbalances in the process of digital repatriation(Bell et al. 2013: 203). At present, digital surrogates of dispersed cultural relics are often still controlled by collecting institutions, in such cross-cultural context, their interpretation is prone to bias and misreading(Dinler 2025:9). The metadata of digital heritage can reflect understanding and interpretation of relevant cultures((Löffler et al. 2020: 238). Through analyzing the **metadata** of dispersed culture relics, the problems of cross-cultural interpretation can be found, which can further help resolve the cultural power disputes in current digital repatriation practice.

Part of dispersed Chinese ancient painting masterpiece Nüshi zhen tu

Research Design

This study refers to the CRM-ACA model of the Palace Museum (Beijing) and China's industry standard "Antique art data element Part 2: Painting and calligraphy" to determine the necessary elements for recording ancient Chinese paintings. Secondly, selecting non-Chinese museums with international influence that collect a large number of Chinese ancient paintings as samples, which are the British Museum the Victoria and Albert Museum, the Metropolitan Museum of Art, the Musée Guimet, the National Museums of Berlin and the Tokyo National Museum. Subsequently, using the web crawler technology to obtain the metadata of the above six museums on ancient Chinese paintings, and then comparing with the necessary elements for recording ancient Chinese paintings from the dimensions of“structural system" and **“description content”** .

Cross-cultural interpretation bias from the perspective of metadata

The results of comparative analysis show that there are significant deviations in metadata structure system and description content of ancient Chinese paintings in non-Chinese museums.

According to Table 1, the metadata structure system of non-Chinese museums shows the following problems: Key cultural categories like Culture are absent in most frameworks, obscuring heritage identity. Artistic elements that show the particularity of Chinese painting are absent, such as Shape, Craft Technique, Mounting. Circulation, management and preservation information

is missing, making it difficult to know the the circulation history and their preservation and restoration status; associated objects lack semantic links, failing to reconstruct cultural knowledge networks.

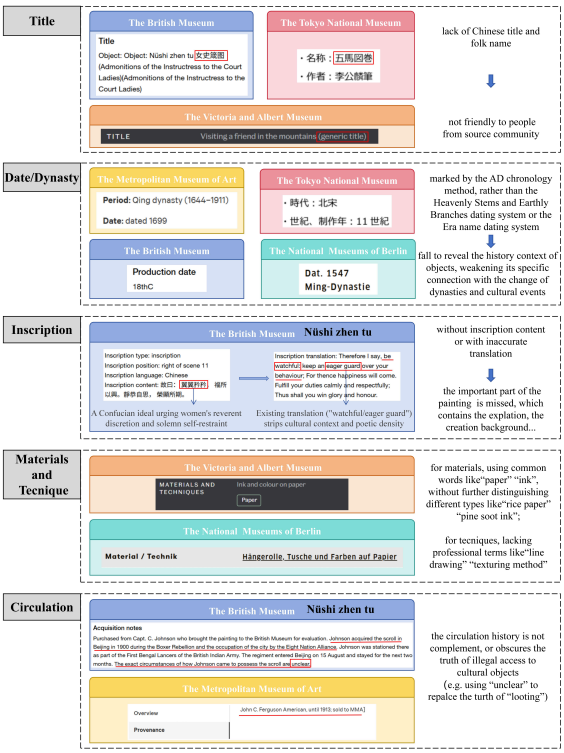
Core elements \ Comparative museums			The British Museum	The Victoria and Albert Museum	The Metropolitan Museum Of Art	The Musée Guimet	The National Museums of Berlin	The Tokyo National Museum
Static Descriptive Metadata	Title		○	○	○	○	○	○
	Chinese title		○		○			
	Museum number		○	○	○	○	○	○
	Location		○	○				
	Artist/Maker		○	○	○		○	○
	Data/Dynasty		○	○	○	○		
	Place of origin		○	○		○		
	Culture		○		○			
	Height/Width/Width		○	○	○	○	○	○
	Materials		○	○	○	○	○	○
	Shape				○			
	Craft Technique		○				○	○
	Genre							
	Type			○	○			○
	Subjects		○	○			○	
	Keywords							○
	Inscription	Inscription type	○					
		Inscription position	○		○			
		Inscription language	○		○			
		Inscription script						
		Inscription content	○	○	○		○	
		Inscriptions Author			○			
	Inscriptions Seal		○	○	○	○		
	Mounting Condition	Mounting Category						
		Mounting Material						
		Mounting Style						
	Appearance							
	Accessory Name							○
	Reference		○	○	○		○	
	Associated objects			○				
	Description		○	○	○	○	○	○

Metadata structure system comparison table#1#

Core elements \ Comparative museums			The British Museum	The Victoria and Albert Museum	The Metropolitan Museum Of Art	The Musée Guimet	The National Museums of Berlin	The Tokyo National Museum
Dynamic Descriptive Metadata	Collection Records	Collector						
		Collection Place						
		Collection Period						
	Transaction Records	Seller				○		○
		Buyer	○			○		○
		Trade Date	○			○		○
	Donation Records	Donator	○	○	○			○
		Accepter						
		Donate Date		○	○			
	Exhibition Records	Exhibition Place	○	○	○			○
		Exhibition Date	○	○	○			○
	Preservation Records	Preserve Place	○	○				
		Preserve Date		○				
		Preserve Condition						
	Treatment Records	Treatment Date	○					○
		Treatment Part						○
		Treatment Technics						○

Metadata structure system comparison table#2#

As for the description content, the above interpretations of ancient Chinese paintings by non-Chinese museums generally have characteristics of westernization, superficializatign and discontextualization, mainly reflected in the following aspects. Firstly, in terms of “period” “materials” and “theme words”, the above non-Chinese museums have not yet formed a unified controlled vocabulary applicable to Chinese culture. Secondly, cultural relics are often viewed from a perspective dominated by Western culture. The ancient Chinese concept of "integrating calligraphy and painting", the meticulous use of paper and ink materials, and the unique artistic techniques formed have not been given much attention. Thirdly, there is a lack of background information. The ways how cultural relics are obtained,managed and preserved by the current occupying country, are often unclear.



Deviation in description content

Reasons and advice

Such deviation and misreading in cross-cultural interpretation may result from: the existing western metadata framework can hardly describe the value of oriental art due to cognitive bias; political tendencies drive collecting institutions to blur the fact of illegal access to cultural relics; the lack of cross-cultural collaboration platform and standardized vocabulary leads to the loss of key cultural information in translation. When digital surrogates of dispersed cultural relics and how these digital objects are interpreted, accessed, circulated and used are still controlled by collecting institutions, the digital repatriation cannot realize the real return of cultural power.

To better solve the cultural disputes in digital repatriation, the following advice can be considered : Firstly, **build a two-way adjustment metadata system** , embed the oriental aesthetic category into international standards. Secondly, cross-cultural collaboration **platforms** , such as Mukurtu and traditional knowledge labels should be promoted, to allow source communities to improve and supervise the interpretation of their own cultural relics. Finally, it is critical to **clarify the ownership of digital surrogates of lost cultural relics clearly** , making the digital surrogates fully mastered by source communities.

Bibliography

Poske, C. (2024). Digital Repatriation of cultural relics. In The Palgrave Encyclopedia of cultural relics and Conflict (pp. 1-5). Cham: Springer Nature Switzerland.

Bell, J. A., Christen, K., & Turin, M. (2013). After the return: Digital repatriation and the circulation of indigenous knowledge workshop report. Museum Worlds, 1(1), 195-203.

Dinler, M. (2024). Metadata and Linked Open Data in Digital Heritage for Decolonization. In The Palgrave Encyclopedia of cultural relics and Conflict (pp. 1-9). Cham: Springer Nature Switzerland.

Löffler, B., & Mager, T. (2020). Minor politics, major consequences: Epistemic challenges of metadata and the contribution of image recognition. Digital Culture & Society, 6(2), 221-238.